

1 Snowmelt regime and dispersal limitation predict the
2 decadal expansion of dwarf bamboo into alpine snowbed
3 vegetation

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5 *Keywords:* alpine vegetation, rhizome expansion, dispersal limitation, habitat
6 suitability modelling, snowmelt timing, time-lapse camera

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7 Abstract

8 Dwarf bamboo (*Sasa* spp.) is expanding into Japanese alpine snowbed vegeta-
9 tion, excluding subordinate species and threatening plant diversity. Mapping
10 its distributional change requires approximately 1 m resolution, because alpine
11 vegetation forms a fine mosaic along microtopographic gradients. Using 10
12 years of ground-based time-lapse imagery of a slope on Mt. Tateyama in the
13 northern Japanese Alps, we produced 1 m vegetation maps for 2012 and 2021
14 and per-pixel snowmelt dates for 2011–2021. Over 9 years, *Sasa* showed a net
15 change of +19% (gross expansion 48%, gross loss 29%; nearly half of the loss was
16 exchange with dwarf pine, of uncertain nature). Because *Sasa* expands through
17 both rhizome elongation and seed dispersal, we fitted two corresponding models
18 under a common spatial-block design: a habitat suitability model of where
19 conditions permit *Sasa* (Model A) and an establishment model of the observed
20 2012→2021 transitions, including distance from the existing front (Model B). In
21 both models, snowmelt climatology, defined as the 2011–2021 mean snowmelt
22 date (day of year, DOY), was among the strongest environmental predictors and
23 indicated a favourable snowmelt window for *Sasa* (habitat suitability was high
24 at approximately DOY 150–185, peaked around DOY 170–175, and declined
25 in the latest-melting snowbeds). Establishment probability, however, was most
26 strongly associated with proximity to existing patches: the 9-year probability
27 was approximately 10% within 5 m of the front and below 1% beyond 10 m. Envi-
28 ronmentally suitable area greatly exceeded occupied area (approximately 16-fold
29 at the threshold maximising the true skill statistic), suggesting that dispersal is
30 a stronger constraint on the current distribution than environment. A stochastic
31 cellular automaton using Model B reproduced the observed 9-year expansion (a
32 calibration check) and projected approximately 4,900 m² of new establishment
33 by 2030 under unchanged snowmelt and 5,700 m² under continuation of the
34 observed trend, which was not statistically detectable over 10 years; these are
35 scenarios conditioned on the observed decade, not forecasts of snowmelt. Approx-
36 imately nine tenths of expected establishment within herbaceous vegetation was
37 concentrated in two snowbed communities adjoining existing patches. Near-term
38 expansion is therefore spatially predictable, making removal or containment at
39 fronts bordering snowbeds a high-priority candidate intervention, complemented
40 by surveillance of the environmental-potential stratum for establishment from
41 seed.

42 1. Introduction

43 Alpine ecosystems are among the most vulnerable to climate change (Hock
44 et al., 2019). Resurveys across mountain regions have documented upslope range
45 shifts, increasing summit species richness, and changes in the composition of
46 high-elevation vegetation (Gottfried et al., 2012; Rumpf et al., 2018; Lamprecht
47 et al., 2018), while satellite observations show widespread greening of alpine
48 landscapes (Carlson et al., 2017). Much of this change reflects the expansion of
49 species that gain a competitive advantage as environmental constraints relax.

50 Examples include woody shrub expansion in Arctic and alpine tundra (Myers-
 51 Smith et al., 2011; Bjorkman et al., 2018) and the encroachment of grasses
 52 and tall forbs into snowbed communities as the snow-free season lengthens
 53 (Grabherr, 2003; Dullinger et al., 2003). In Japanese alpine ecosystems, dwarf
 54 bamboo (*Sasa* spp., hereafter *Sasa*) represents a prominent example. *Sasa* forms
 55 dense evergreen stands that exclude subordinate species, and its expansion into
 56 snowbed meadows has been associated with earlier snowmelt and reductions in
 57 plant species richness (Kudo et al., 2011). Snowbed vegetation has recovered
 58 following experimental removal of *Sasa* (Kudo et al., 2017). Understanding
 59 where and how rapidly *Sasa* expands is therefore directly relevant to alpine plant
 60 conservation.

61 Snowmelt timing is a central environmental factor for alpine vegetation because
 62 it determines the onset and duration of the growing season and is closely linked
 63 to growing conditions such as soil temperature and moisture (Wipf and Rixen,
 64 2010; Wahren et al., 2005); snowmelt date is therefore a proxy for a set of
 65 covarying conditions rather than a single driver. Spatial scale matters here.
 66 Snowmelt varies with microtopography over distances of a few to tens of metres,
 67 and alpine vegetation forms a fine mosaic of communities along these snowmelt
 68 gradients. Linking changes in alpine plant distributions to environmental condi-
 69 tions therefore requires simultaneous observations of vegetation and snowmelt at
 70 approximately 1 m resolution. Field plots capture this scale but lack continuous
 71 spatial coverage. Satellites provide decades of snow and vegetation observations
 72 at 10–30 m resolution, but cannot resolve community mosaics or movements
 73 of patch boundaries. Ground-based time-lapse cameras fill this gap. Repeated
 74 daily photographs from a fixed viewpoint allow automated extraction of both
 75 per-pixel snowmelt dates and vegetation maps at sub-metre ground resolution
 76 (Ide and Oguma, 2013; Okamoto et al., 2024). The two approaches are therefore
 77 complementary: the expansion patterns that satellites record over decades and at
 78 scales of tens of metres can be examined through observations of the metre-scale
 79 processes that underlie them.

80 *Sasa* expands through two contrasting dispersal processes (Suyama et al., 2000;
 81 Kudo et al., 2011). The first is the gradual advance of patch fronts through
 82 rhizome elongation; where this process dominates, expansion may be limited
 83 by the rate of dispersal rather than by the extent of environmentally suitable
 84 habitat. The second is establishment from seed following mass or partial flowering
 85 (Miyazaki et al., 2009; Mizuki et al., 2014), which can bypass local distance
 86 constraints and form new patches. Conservation planning requires information
 87 on both: where environmental conditions permit *Sasa* to establish if seeds
 88 arrive, and how far existing fronts can actually reach. For the former question,
 89 habitat suitability models, statistical frameworks relating species presence to
 90 environmental conditions, have been widely used in conservation planning and
 91 projections of distributional change (Guisan et al., 1998; Larson et al., 2004;
 92 Thomas et al., 2004; Gallien et al., 2010; Amagai et al., 2022). Projecting
 93 suitability maps without accounting for dispersal constraints, however, can greatly
 94 overestimate establishment area (Engler and Guisan, 2009; Engler et al., 2012).

95 Answering the latter question requires distribution maps of the same area at two
 96 or more times. Comparing two maps reveals the cells in which establishment
 97 actually occurred. These observed transitions can then be modelled directly
 98 as a function of environment and distance from the existing front, projecting
 99 expansion as a process rather than as a reassessment of a static suitability map.

100 Here, we apply this approach to *Sasa* on the western slope of Mt. Tateyama
 101 in the northern Japanese Alps. Plot resurveys on the Murodo-daira plateau
 102 have documented 44–260% expansion of *Sasa* patches over 38 years (Yoshida
 103 et al., 2016). Using 10 years of time-lapse imagery, we (i) map *Sasa* distributions
 104 in 2012 and 2021 at 1 m resolution and quantify gross expansion, gross loss,
 105 and net change; (ii) characterise the snowmelt regime and its decadal trend
 106 for every pixel; (iii) fit a habitat suitability model of environmental potential
 107 (Model A) and an establishment model of observed transitions (Model B) to
 108 estimate how strongly snowmelt regime and topography are associated with
 109 *Sasa* distribution and establishment, while accounting for proximity to existing
 110 patches; (iv) project establishment to 2030 under explicit snowmelt scenarios
 111 using stochastic simulations based on the establishment model; and (v) identify
 112 the alpine communities most exposed to near-term expansion.

113 2. Materials and Methods

114 Figure 1 presents an overview of the workflow. Using time-lapse imagery, we
 115 (i) produced vegetation classification maps for 2012 and 2021 to quantify 9-year
 116 changes in *Sasa* distribution and (ii) characterised the snowmelt regime and its
 117 temporal trend from per-pixel snowmelt dates for 2011–2021, expressed as day
 118 of year (DOY). We then (iii) fitted two statistical models, a habitat suitability
 119 model of environmental potential (Model A) and an establishment model of the
 120 observed 2012–2021 transitions (Model B), and (iv) projected establishment to
 121 2030 under explicit snowmelt scenarios using a stochastic cellular automaton
 122 based on Model B. All spatial analyses used a common 1 m grid (JGD2011 /
 123 UTM zone 53N, EPSG:6690).

124 2.1. Study site

125 The study slope lies on the western side of Mt. Tateyama (Murodo-daira
 126 and the surrounding slopes, 2,350–3,015 m a.s.l.) in the northern Japanese
 127 Alps, within Chubu-Sangaku National Park, Toyama Prefecture. The region is
 128 among the snowiest alpine environments in the world. Airborne laser surveys
 129 at peak snow accumulation show that mean snow depth on the western slope
 130 of Mt. Tateyama increases linearly with elevation, reaching approximately
 131 6–7 m at Murodo-daira, with substantially greater local depths in snowdrifts
 132 (Iida et al., 2006). The plateau consists of pyroclastic deposits from Tateyama
 133 Volcano, and the slopes are dissected by avalanche tracks and hollows that retain
 134 snow. Snowmelt progresses from wind-exposed ridges, typically in May–June, to
 135 snowbed hollows where snow persists into August, creating steep gradients in
 136 growing-season length over horizontal distances of tens of metres.

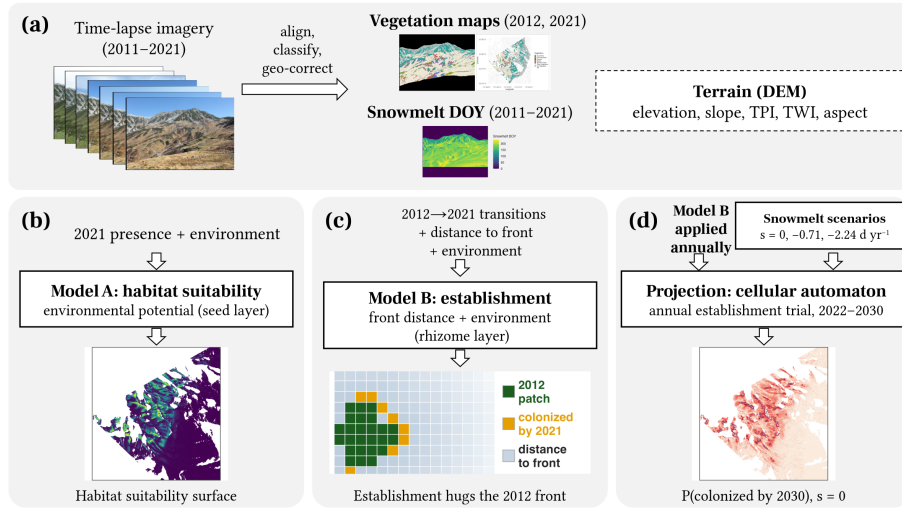


Figure 1: Images from a single fixed camera support two models corresponding to the two modes of *Sasa* expansion and projections of future establishment. (a) Data generation: alignment, classification, and georectification of time-lapse imagery produce vegetation maps (2012, 2021) and per-pixel snowmelt DOY (2011–2021). Terrain variables are derived from a DEM. (b) Model A: presence in 2021 and environmental conditions are used to estimate a habitat suitability surface (environmental potential; seed-dispersal stratum). (c) Model B: observed 2012→2021 transitions are modelled as a function of distance from the front and environment (rhizome stratum). Establishment is concentrated along the edges of 2012 patches, as illustrated by the orange cells in the schematic. (d) Projection: a stochastic cellular automaton applying Model B annually, updating the distance surface each year and taking snowmelt scenario s as input, yields establishment probabilities by 2030.

137 The vegetation forms a mosaic typical of the snowy alpine zone of central Japan:
 138 dwarf pine scrub on exposed sites, snowbed communities in late-melting hollows,
 139 tall-forb meadows on moist slopes, and deciduous shrubs (rowans, maple, and
 140 montane alder) along streams and avalanche tracks. *Sasa* forms dense stands
 141 near the lower limit of the alpine zone and occurs as scattered patches within the
 142 study slope. Although the area receives intensive tourist use via the Tateyama
 143 Kurobe Alpine Route, visitors remain on maintained trails, and the observed
 144 slope is not directly affected by trampling. No vegetation management or *Sasa*
 145 removal took place on the slope during the study period.

146 2.2. Image acquisition

147 We used images captured by a digital time-lapse camera (EOS 5D Mark II,
 148 Canon Inc., 21 megapixels) installed by the National Institute for Environmental
 149 Studies on the Murodo-sanso mountain lodge (approximately 2,450 m a.s.l.).
 150 Since 2010, the camera has photographed the slope hourly from 6:00 to 19:00
 151 between April and November. For details of the installation and operation,
 152 see Okamoto et al. (2024). Vegetation classification used images acquired in
 153 August–October of 2012 and 2021 (7 frames per year), and snowmelt detection
 154 used images from April–August of each year during 2011–2021. Data for 2019 are
 155 missing because of construction work at the mountain lodge housing the camera.
 156 Images from 2010 were excluded because a different lens gave an incompatible
 157 field of view. Snowmelt detection followed the workflow of Ide and Oguma (2013),
 158 which is based on Otsu’s binarisation method (Otsu, 1979). Detectable snowmelt
 159 dates were censored by the imaging season (approximately DOY 120–230), and
 160 pixels without valid detections, including sky and permanently occluded terrain,
 161 were treated as missing.

162 2.3. Vegetation classification maps

163 Vegetation classification maps were produced using the three-step pipeline of
 164 Okamoto et al. (2024).

- 165 • **Image alignment.** All frames from both years were aligned to a com-
 166 mon reference frame by matching AKAZE local features and estimating
 167 projective transformations with RANSAC in OpenCV. Median residual
 168 misalignment between the 2012 and 2021 series was 1–2 pixels, with no
 169 systematic offset between years.
- 170 • **Vegetation classification.** Each pixel was assigned to one of 7 classes:
 171 dwarf pine (*Pinus pumila*), dwarf bamboo (*Sasa* spp.), rowans (*Sorbus*
 172 *sambucifolia*, *S. matsumurana*), maple (*Acer tschonoskii*), montane alder
 173 (*Alnus viridis* subsp. *maximowiczii*), other vegetation (alpine herbs and
 174 dwarf shrubs such as crowberry and avens), and no vegetation. The
 175 classifier was a convolutional recurrent neural network (Conv2D–LSTM on
 176 5×5-pixel patches) using temporal changes in leaf colour across seasonal
 177 image sequences. Training labels comprised 216 hand-drawn polygons,
 178 delineated mainly on 2015 imagery and checked against the 2012 and 2021
 179 image sequences. Overall accuracy in 5-fold cross-validation was 0.982 for

the 2012 series and 0.975 for the 2021 series (class-specific accuracy, network architecture, and training procedures are provided in the Supporting Information; Table S2). However, cross-validation splits were made at the pixel rather than polygon level, and the same labelled polygons were applied to both years. These estimates therefore disproportionately reflect accuracy near the training polygons; classification accuracy at unseen locations farther from the training data may be lower.

- **Georectification.** Ground control points were automatically extracted from orthorectified aerial photographs and a DEM to estimate camera parameters, and images were projected onto the 1 m analysis grid using the Python package `alproj` (<https://github.com/Okam/alproj>) (Okamoto et al., 2024). Median ground-control-point residuals were approximately 2 pixels, and the raster maps were completed with a single gap-filling pass using a 3×3 modal filter.

2.4. Quantification of *Sasa* change

We overlaid the 2012 and 2021 vegetation maps (Figure S5) and calculated a transition matrix for all classes. Throughout, we distinguish three quantities: **gross expansion**, the area transitioning from non-*Sasa* to *Sasa*; **gross loss**, the area transitioning from *Sasa* to non-*Sasa*; and **net change**, their difference. Areas are reported as the sum of the actual areas of 1 m cells measured on the Earth’s ellipsoid (geodesic area). These are nearly identical to nominal areas calculated as cell count $\times 1 \text{ m}^2$ (difference $< 0.1\%$); figure legends and model sample sizes refer to cell counts. Because *Sasa* can persist beneath shrub canopies, apparent loss may reflect canopy cover or shifts in the classification of mixed *Sasa*–shrub pixels rather than true decline. We report the destination classes of loss in the Results and address this ambiguity in the Discussion. To test whether apparent loss to dwarf pine was concentrated at boundaries, we calculated the Euclidean distance from every *Sasa*→dwarf pine cell to the nearest 2012 dwarf pine cell and binned the distances (1.5, 1.5–3, 3–5, and > 5 m), using all 2012 *Sasa* cells as the reference distribution; transition cells more than 5 m from 2012 dwarf pine were grouped into clusters by 8-neighbour connectivity and inspected individually (Table S4, Figure S6). To assess the nature of the transitions empirically, we conducted a blind interpretation of paired images. A total of 129 samples comprised 79 stratified samples of loss cells, proportional to the composition of destination classes, 40 stable controls (20 *Sasa* in both years and 20 dwarf pine in both years), and 10 reverse transitions (dwarf pine→*Sasa*). Paired image crops from 2012 and 2021 were presented in random order with transition types concealed; the interpreter was not told that stable controls and reverse transitions were interleaved among the loss cells. Each sample included two pairs, one from the green-leaf season and one from the autumn-colour season; frames with similar image greenness were paired to reduce misinterpretation arising from differences in leaf colour between acquisition dates. The first author assigned each sample to one of four interpretation categories: *Sasa* loss, canopy cover, boundary ambiguity, or indeterminate (full design and results in Table S5).

225 2.5. Snowmelt regime and trends

226 For every 1 m cell, we compiled 10 years of annual snowmelt DOY (2011–2021,
 227 excluding the missing year 2019) and calculated (i) **snowmelt climatology**,
 228 the 2011–2021 mean snowmelt date (DOY), which averages over interannual
 229 variation to represent the prevailing snowmelt timing at each location, and (ii)
 230 a per-pixel linear trend, the slope of an ordinary least-squares regression of
 231 DOY against year, estimated for cells with at least 8 valid years. Per-pixel
 232 slopes were tested with two-sided t tests, and p values were adjusted across
 233 cells by the Benjamini–Hochberg procedure; at the landscape scale, we regressed
 234 the 10 annual spatial means of snowmelt DOY on year. As a perennial plant,
 235 *Sasa* is expected to respond to the prevailing local snowmelt regime rather than
 236 snowmelt in any single year, so both models used snowmelt climatology as the
 237 environmental predictor. Trends were not included as predictors. Per-pixel
 238 trend estimates are noisy, with a detection limit of approximately 2 days/year
 239 as discussed below, and adding the trend to Model B did not improve prediction
 240 in held-out spatial blocks (Table S1, Figure S4).

241 The trends require careful interpretation. With a 10-year record and a residual
 242 annual SD of approximately 9 days, the minimum detectable per-pixel slope
 243 is approximately 2 days/year; trends of plausible magnitude therefore cannot
 244 be detected statistically. Accordingly, trends were used only to parameterise
 245 scenarios for the 2030 projections (Section 2.7), not as evidence that a change
 246 in snowmelt had been demonstrated. Forecasting snowmelt timing itself was
 247 beyond the scope of this study.

248 2.6. Statistical models

249 We addressed the two questions set out in the Introduction, where environmental
 250 conditions permit *Sasa* and where observed establishment occurred, using two
 251 models with a shared evaluation design.

252 **Shared predictors.** Both models used slope, elevation, topographic position
 253 index (TPI; the difference between the elevation of a cell and the mean elevation
 254 of its eight neighbours, distinguishing ridges from hollows), topographic wetness
 255 index (TWI; $\ln(a/\tan \theta)$, with contributing area a and slope θ (Beven and Kirkby,
 256 1979)), northness ($\cos$ aspect), and eastness ($\sin$ aspect), derived from the
 257 Fundamental Geospatial Data digital elevation model (DEM) of the Geospatial
 258 Information Authority of Japan (Geospatial Information Authority of Japan,
 259 2026) (approximately 5 m mesh) and reprojected to the analysis grid, together
 260 with snowmelt climatology (Section 2.5). Slope, aspect, and TPI were computed
 261 with the GDAL `gdaldem` utility (slope and aspect by the Zevenbergen–Thorne
 262 algorithm (Zevenbergen and Thorne, 1987)); TWI was computed in QGIS
 263 with SAGA GIS (Conrad et al., 2015). The effective resolution of the terrain
 264 predictors is therefore that of the source DEM rather than 1 m; details of
 265 terrain-variable derivation are provided in the Supporting Information. Aspect, a
 266 circular variable, was decomposed into northness and eastness before reprojection.
 267 Terrain roughness and terrain ruggedness index were excluded before modelling

because of strong collinearity with slope (Spearman $|r| = 0.93\text{--}0.97$). All retained predictors had variance inflation factors of at most 2.30 and pairwise $|r|$ below 0.7 (Table S7).

Shared evaluation design. A single set of spatial blocks was defined across the full analysis domain using `spatialsample` (Mahoney et al., 2023): a 10×10 grid of rectangular blocks (each approximately 180×175 m) over the analysis extent, assigned at random to 4 folds, and used for tuning, ensemble construction, and held-out evaluation of both models. Model comparisons thus used the same evaluation areas.

2.6.1. Model A: environmental potential

Model A was a habitat suitability model fitted to the 2021 *Sasa* distribution. Presences were *Sasa* cells at 1 m resolution; pseudo-absences were non-*Sasa* cells thinned to one per 5 m cell to reduce class imbalance. We tuned four algorithms in `tidysdm` (Leonardi et al., 2024) by grid search with up to 18 candidates per algorithm: gradient boosted trees (Friedman, 2001), MaxEnt (Phillips et al., 2006), random forest (Breiman, 2001), and generalised additive models. Candidates were selected by TSS on spatial blocks and blended using LASSO-regularised stacking (Couch and Kuhn, 2024). The final ensemble composition is reported in the Results. Performance is reported as the True Skill Statistic (TSS; Allouche et al. (2006)) and AUC on held-out spatial blocks. The main outputs were a continuous map of habitat suitability on a 0–1 scale (the suitability surface) and partial dependence profiles for each predictor, computed with the `DALEX` and `DALEXtra` packages. Where binarisation was needed, we used the threshold maximising TSS on held-out predictions; sensitivity of suitable area to thresholds of 0.1–0.7 is reported in Table S8. The main model used the full elevation range of the mapped slope. Results for a sensitivity variant restricting the domain to elevations below 2,560 m, the upper limit of the observed distribution, are provided in Table S6.

2.6.2. Model B: establishment model

Model B directly modelled observed transitions. For all cells that were non-*Sasa* in 2012 ($n = 1,197,536$; this count includes 5,147 cells that were unclassified in 2012, none of which became *Sasa*, whereas Table S3 is restricted to cells classified in both years), the response was whether they had become *Sasa* by 2021 (establishment; $n = 4,095$). Predictors comprised the shared environmental variables and distance from the 2012 *Sasa* front. Distance was calculated as the Euclidean distance to the nearest cell belonging to a 2012 *Sasa* patch exceeding 5 m^2 in geodesic area, with patches defined by 4-neighbour connectivity. This patch-size rule prevented tiny patches arising from classification noise from dominating the estimated expansion process: because area gain through rhizome elongation is proportional to patch perimeter, tiny patches with the highest perimeter-to-area ratios have disproportionate influence.

We fitted a binomial generalised additive model (GAM; `bam` in `mgcv` (Wood, 2011)) to all eligible cells, using thin-plate spline smooths for all predictors. The

distance term used a logarithmic transformation, $s(\log(1 + d))$, concentrating smooth flexibility near the front, where observations were densest (criteria for specification choice are provided in Table S9). Basis dimensions were $k = 5$ for the distance smooth and $k = 10$ for the environmental smooths. Model B was evaluated by leave-one-block-out refitting on the shared spatial partition. As a robustness comparison, we also fitted a gradient boosted tree ensemble to the same response and predictors on the same folds, using all establishment cells and a fold-stratified random sample of 150,000 non-establishment cells; because its negative set differs, its AUC is an approximate comparison. The estimated dispersal kernel is presented as mean predicted establishment probability alongside observed establishment rates in distance bands of 0–5, 5–10, 10–20, 20–40, 40–80, 80–160, and 160 m and beyond.

2.7. Projections to 2030

Model A’s suitability map describes the extent of environmentally permissive habitat, whereas rhizome expansion can proceed only from existing fronts. Applying the suitability map directly to the future would therefore greatly overestimate near-term establishment area. We instead projected establishment using a stochastic cellular automaton that applied Model B annually, and used Model A as the environmental-potential stratum corresponding to seed dispersal (Section 2.8). Projections thus arose from the expansion process itself rather than from a suitability threshold.

Starting from the observed 2021 distribution, we repeated the following steps for each year from 2022 to 2030. (i) Recalculate the distance surface from the current simulated distribution using the same 5 m² patch rule as in model fitting. (ii) Evaluate the 9-year establishment probability p_9 from Model B for every unoccupied cell and convert it to an annual probability: $p_1 = 1 - (1 - p_9)^{1/9}$. (iii) Draw establishment independently for each cell from a Bernoulli distribution, retaining occupancy once established (assuming no loss within the 9-year period). For computational efficiency, the environmental component of the linear predictor was precomputed for each scenario $\times$ year, and only the distance term was updated within the simulation; this decomposition is exact (Supporting Information). We ran 200 replicates per scenario (50 replicates for the spatial validation and structural sensitivity runs described below) and report per-cell establishment probabilities (means across replicates) and expected new establishment area (the sum of probability $\times$ cell area). The latter requires no binarisation threshold.

Scenarios. Snowmelt climatology was shifted linearly by $s \times (\text{year} - 2016)$, where 2016 is the midpoint of the averaging period. In the main text, we report $s = 0$ (no change, consistent with the absence of a detectable trend) and $s = -0.71$ days/year (the mean of the per-pixel slopes, close to the landscape-scale point estimate of -0.69 days/year); $s = -2.24$ days/year (the lower confidence limit of the landscape-scale trend) is reported as an extreme scenario in Table S11. These are scenarios conditional on the observed decade, not forecasts of snowmelt. Shifts were spatially uniform because per-pixel trend estimates are dominated by

noise and cannot be directly extrapolated (Section 2.5). The uniform shift is an approximation, justified in the Supporting Information alongside an assessment of the spatial structure of per-pixel trends (Figure S4).

Validation. We conducted three checks. (1) *Hindcast*: we tested whether simulations initialised from the 2012 distribution reproduced the observed 2012–2021 gross expansion. Because Model B was fitted to the same interval, this is a calibration check rather than independent validation. (2) *Independent spatial validation*: for each spatial block, we refitted Model B excluding that block and scored the hindcast only within the omitted block. (3) *Structural sensitivity*: we quantified changes in the projections when the 5 m² patch rule was removed from distance updates and when annualisation was replaced by the first-order approximation $p_9/9$.

2.8. Risk to alpine communities

We present two risk strata corresponding to the two modes of *Sasa* expansion. The **near-term rhizome stratum** comprised cellular-automaton establishment probabilities restricted to cells classified as other vegetation in 2021, a class dominated by alpine herbs and including snowbed communities of conservation concern, summarised as expected establishment area. To identify the communities at risk, we overlaid the 1:25,000 vegetation GIS map compiled under the National Survey on the Natural Environment by the Biodiversity Center of Japan, Nature Conservation Bureau, Ministry of the Environment (Hokuriku block) (Ministry of the Environment, 2026) and cross-tabulated expected establishment area by mapped community. The scale mismatch between 1:25,000 polygons and the 1 m grid is addressed as a limitation in the Discussion. The **seed-dispersal stratum** represented environmental potential in 2021, namely cells at or above the TSS-maximising threshold of Model A (Figure S7). Because establishment from seed is not constrained by the modelled distance process, environmental potential provides a first approximation of the area that could be exposed; unmeasured factors such as soils and constraints on seedling establishment are not accounted for. Field validation of community composition and assessment of rare-species occurrence within risk areas remain future work.

2.9. Software and reproducibility

All analyses used R 4.5.2 (terra, sf, tidymodels/tidysdm, stacks, spatialsample, mgcv, xgboost, ranger, maxnet, DALEX) in a scripted, non-interactive pipeline with fixed random seeds defined in a single configuration script; package versions are recorded in the `sessionInfo()` logs archived with the code. The vegetation classifier was implemented in Python with PyTorch, and image alignment used OpenCV. Code and data are archived at Zenodo (<https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.22745234>).

3. Results

3.1. *Sasa* expanded by a net +19% over 9 years

The area classified as *Sasa* (geodesic area) increased from 8,542 m² in 2012 to 10,170 m² in 2021, a net change of +1,628 m² (+19%) over 9 years. This net change reflects the difference between gross expansion of 4,095 cells (non-*Sasa*→*Sasa*; 48% of the 2012 area) and gross loss of 2,468 cells (*Sasa*→non-*Sasa*; 29%) (Figure 2; the full transition matrix is in Table S3; the nominal area of a cell is 1 m² and differs from its geodesic area by <0.1%). Expansion originated mainly from other vegetation (53%) and dwarf pine (35%), with the three deciduous shrub classes (rowans, maple, and montane alder) together accounting for 12%. Loss was predominantly to dwarf pine (47%) and other vegetation (38%), with the three deciduous shrub classes together accounting for 15%. Dwarf pine and *Sasa* exchanged area in both directions (interpretation in Section 4.1). In the blind interpretation of paired images, 73–87% of loss cells were assigned to boundary ambiguity, a proportion essentially unchanged from that in stable controls (80–85%). Canopy cover was assigned to 22% (8/37) of *Sasa*→dwarf pine transition cells, only slightly above the corresponding judgement for stable dwarf pine controls (15%, 3/20). Thus, the nature of transitions in individual 1 m cells could not be resolved at the photographic scale (Table S5). A few mapped 2021 *Sasa* cells were isolated from all 2012 *Sasa* cells, but these could not be distinguished from classification noise, and no isolated new patches were visually confirmed.

3.2. *Snowmelt timing followed microtopographic gradients, with no detectable trend over 10 years*

Snowmelt climatology ranged from approximately DOY 120 to 230 across the slope, following a ridge-to-hollow gradient (Figure S2). Per-pixel linear trends were negative in 91.7% of cells, positive in 8.3%, and zero in 0.06% (mean −0.71 days/year, median −0.63, SD 0.63; Figure S3), but annual spatial means varied markedly among years and provided little evidence for a landscape-scale trend (−0.69 days/year, 95% confidence interval −2.24 to +0.87, $p = 0.34$; Figure S1). Only 2.0% of cells had individually significant slopes ($p < 0.05$), and none remained significant after false-discovery-rate correction. Given the power limitations described in Section 2.5, the record for this period is consistent with a gradual advance in snowmelt but does not demonstrate it; trends are used below only to define scenarios.

3.3. *Environmentally suitable area greatly exceeded occupied area (Model A)*

The main Model A, covering the full elevation range, achieved a held-out TSS of 0.78 (mean across 4 spatial blocks; range 0.72–0.85) and an AUC of 0.95. Four members remained in the LASSO blend: 2 gradient boosted tree models, 1 MaxEnt model, and 1 random forest, with boosted trees and MaxEnt accounting for approximately 97% of the blend weight. Response curves (Figure 3) showed high habitat suitability at a snowmelt climatology of approximately

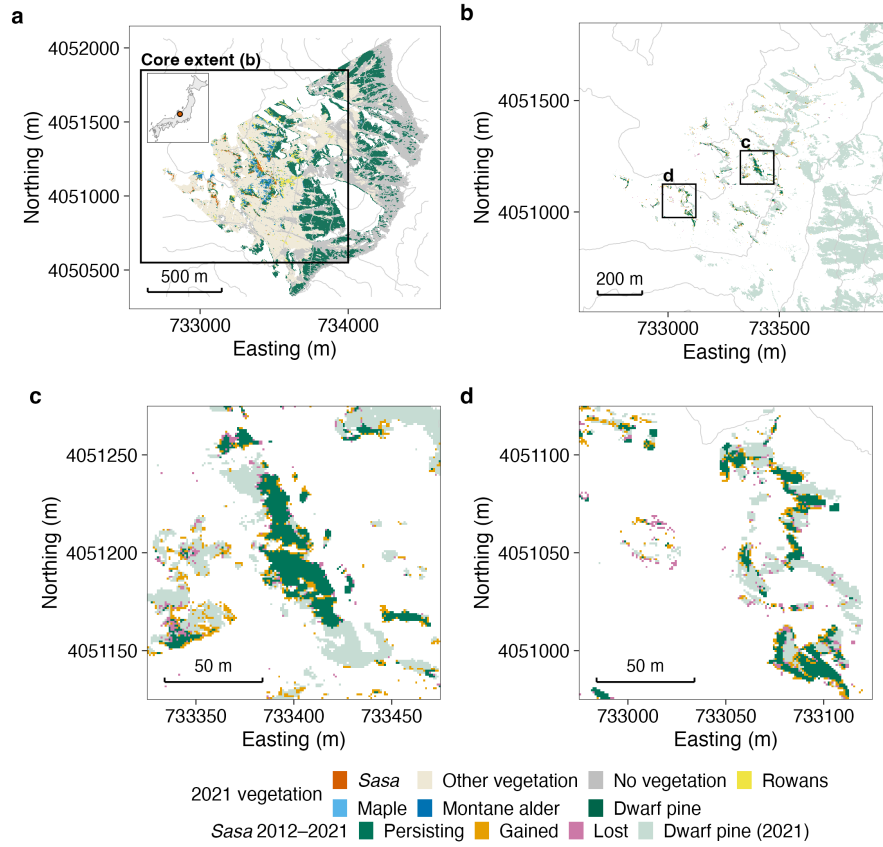


Figure 2: Changes in *Sasa* over 9 years were concentrated along the edges of existing patches. (a) Study site and 2021 vegetation map. The black box marks the core area in (b), and the inset locates the site within Japan. (b) *Sasa* change in the core area: persistence (*Sasa* in both years, 6,079 cells), gain (4,095 cells), and loss (2,468 cells). Pale green denotes dwarf pine in 2021, and white denotes all other classes. (c) A representative expansion front. (d) A representative *Sasa*→dwarf pine boundary; boxes in (b) locate the examples. Grey lines are 100 m contours. Area values are nominal areas based on cell counts.

DOY 150–185, peaking near DOY 172 and declining in later-melting snowbeds. Habitat suitability also declined with elevation and peaked at intermediate slopes. Responses to TPI, TWI, and aspect components were weaker and non-monotonic. Because estimates of suitable area depend strongly on the binarisation threshold, we primarily used the threshold of 0.16 that maximised TSS on held-out predictions (full threshold sensitivity in Table S8). At this threshold, suitable area was $164 \times 10^3 \text{ m}^2$, approximately 16 times the observed occupied area of $10.2 \times 10^3 \text{ m}^2$. Suitable area consistently exceeded occupied area at thresholds up to 0.55 (Figure 4 a).

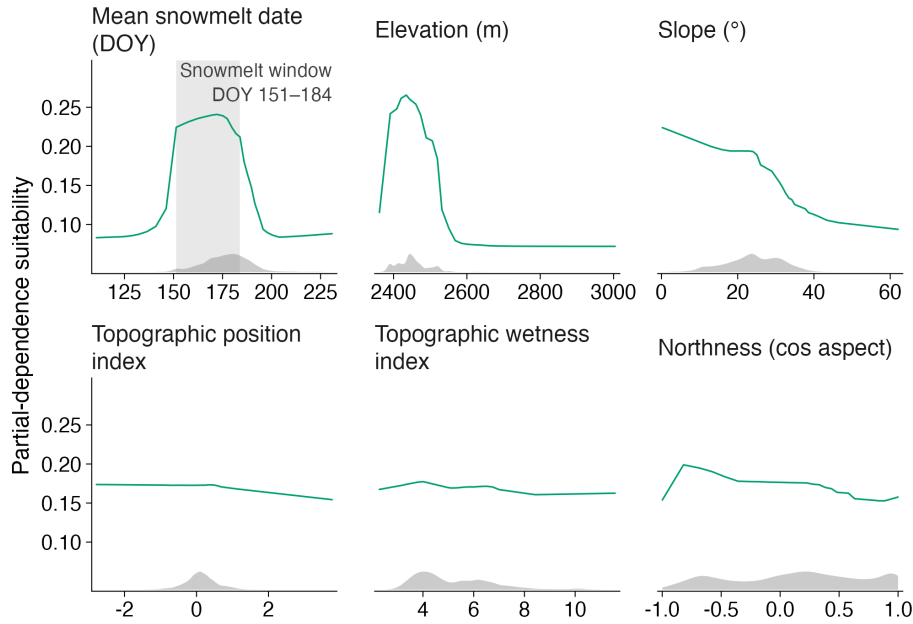


Figure 3: Model A habitat suitability was highest at a snowmelt climatology of approximately DOY 150–185, indicating a favourable snowmelt window for *Sasa* (shading; DOY 151–184, where suitability was at or above 85% of its peak). Each panel shows a partial dependence response curve for the main Model A variant. Grey bands along the bottom of the panels show the distribution (density) of each predictor in presence cells.

3.4. Establishment depended strongly on distance from the existing front (Model B)

Of the 1,197,536 cells that were non-*Sasa* in 2012, 4,095 had become *Sasa* by 2021. The establishment GAM discriminated well between establishment and non-establishment cells in leave-one-block-out evaluation (pooled AUC 0.946, TSS 0.75; block-specific AUC 0.91–0.96). A gradient boosted tree ensemble fitted on the same folds to all establishment cells and a fold-stratified sample of 150,000 non-establishment cells achieved an AUC of 0.948, indicating that the additive model captured nearly all the signal available to a more flexible learner. Distance

454 from the 2012 front was the strongest term. The 9-year establishment probability
 455 declined from approximately 10% within 5 m of the front to approximately 1% at
 456 5–10 m and below 0.1% beyond 80 m. Fitted distance-band probabilities closely
 457 matched observed establishment rates throughout the range (Figure 4 e; the
 458 largest discrepancy was 0.5 percentage points in the 0–5 m band). Environmental
 459 associations were consistent with Model A: establishment probability was higher
 460 at late-melting (but not the latest-melting) sites, at lower elevations, and on
 461 gentler slopes. The map of 9-year establishment probability evaluated from
 462 the 2021 front (Figure 4 b) was concentrated in narrow bands around existing
 463 patches, with the highest values along their lower, late-melting edges.

464 3.5. *Projected establishment continued near existing fronts, with limited sensitivity* 465 *to snowmelt scenarios*

466 The projection model reproduced the observed change before it was extrapolated.
 467 The cellular automaton initialised from the 2012 distribution reproduced the
 468 observed 2012–2021 gross expansion (expected 4,414 m², observed 4,093 m²; ratio
 469 1.08; cell-level AUC 0.92). This was a calibration check. In independent spatial
 470 validation, in which each block was predicted by a model never exposed to that
 471 block, AUC ranged from 0.79 to 0.86, whereas block-level ratios of expected to
 472 observed area ranged from 0.67 to 2.0. Discrimination of establishment *location*
 473 was stable across blocks, but prediction errors in the *amount* of establishment
 474 were substantial.

475 Starting from the 2021 distribution, expected new establishment area by 2030
 476 was 4,901 m² under the no-change scenario ($s = 0$; SD across replicates 70) and
 477 5,730 m² under continued snowmelt advance at the observed rate ($s = -0.71$
 478 days/year; SD 84), the latter 17% greater than the former (Figure 5). Both
 479 trajectories were nearly linear over 9 years, and both were of similar magnitude to
 480 the observed 2012–2021 gross expansion (geodesic area 4,093 m²). Establishment
 481 probability was highest along the lower, snowbed-facing edges of existing patches
 482 and negligible more than a few tens of metres from any patch (Figure 5 a, b). The
 483 extreme scenario at the lower confidence limit of the trend ($s = -2.24$ days/year)
 484 yielded 5,524 m², slightly *less* than the point-estimate scenario (Table S11).
 485 Projected area was not a monotonic function of earlier snowmelt (mechanism
 486 discussed in Section 4.2). Structural sensitivity of the projections is reported in
 487 Table S10.

488 3.6. *Near-term risk was concentrated in two snowbed communities adjoining* 489 *existing patches*

490 Within cells classified as other vegetation in 2021, the expected establishment
 491 area by 2030 was 2,429 m² ($s = 0$) and 3,383 m² ($s = -0.71$ days/year) (Figure 6
 492 a). Overlain on the Ministry of the Environment’s 1:25,000 vegetation map,
 493 73–74% of this expected area fell in the *Fauria crista-galli*–*Carex blepharicarpa*
 494 snowbed community and a further 15–16% in the *Anaphalis alpicola*–*Phyllodoce*
 495 *aleutica* snowbed community; together, approximately nine tenths of the expected
 496 area lay in snowbed vegetation. The remaining tenth was mapped as dwarf

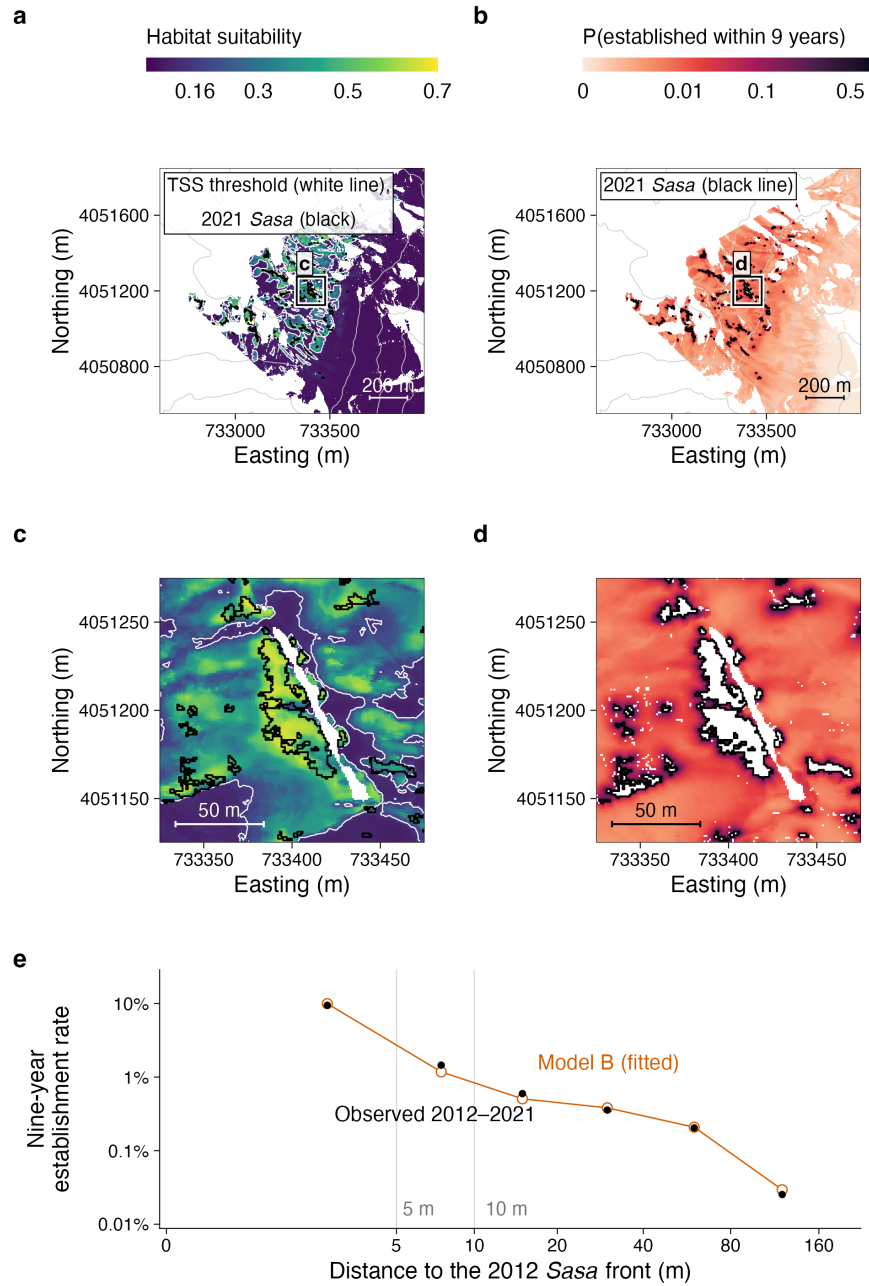


Figure 4: Environmentally suitable area greatly exceeded occupied area, but 9-year establishment was confined to a band within a few metres of the front. (a) Habitat suitability surface from the main Model A variant. White lines mark the TSS-maximising threshold (0.16), and black lines show the 2021 *Sasa* distribution, restricted to patches exceeding 5 m² in geodesic area, as in subsequent figures. (b) Model B 9-year establishment probability evaluated from the 2021 front. (c, d) Enlargements of the 150 m windows (black boxes) in (a) and (b), respectively. In (d), high establishment probabilities trace the edges of existing patches in bands one to a few cells wide. (e) Observed 9-year establishment rates (black points) and Model B fitted probabilities (orange; distance-band means connected by lines) by distance from the 2012 front. Both axes are logarithmic. The open-ended band at 160 m and beyond is omitted because it has no defined midpoint (observed establishment rate 0.0069%).

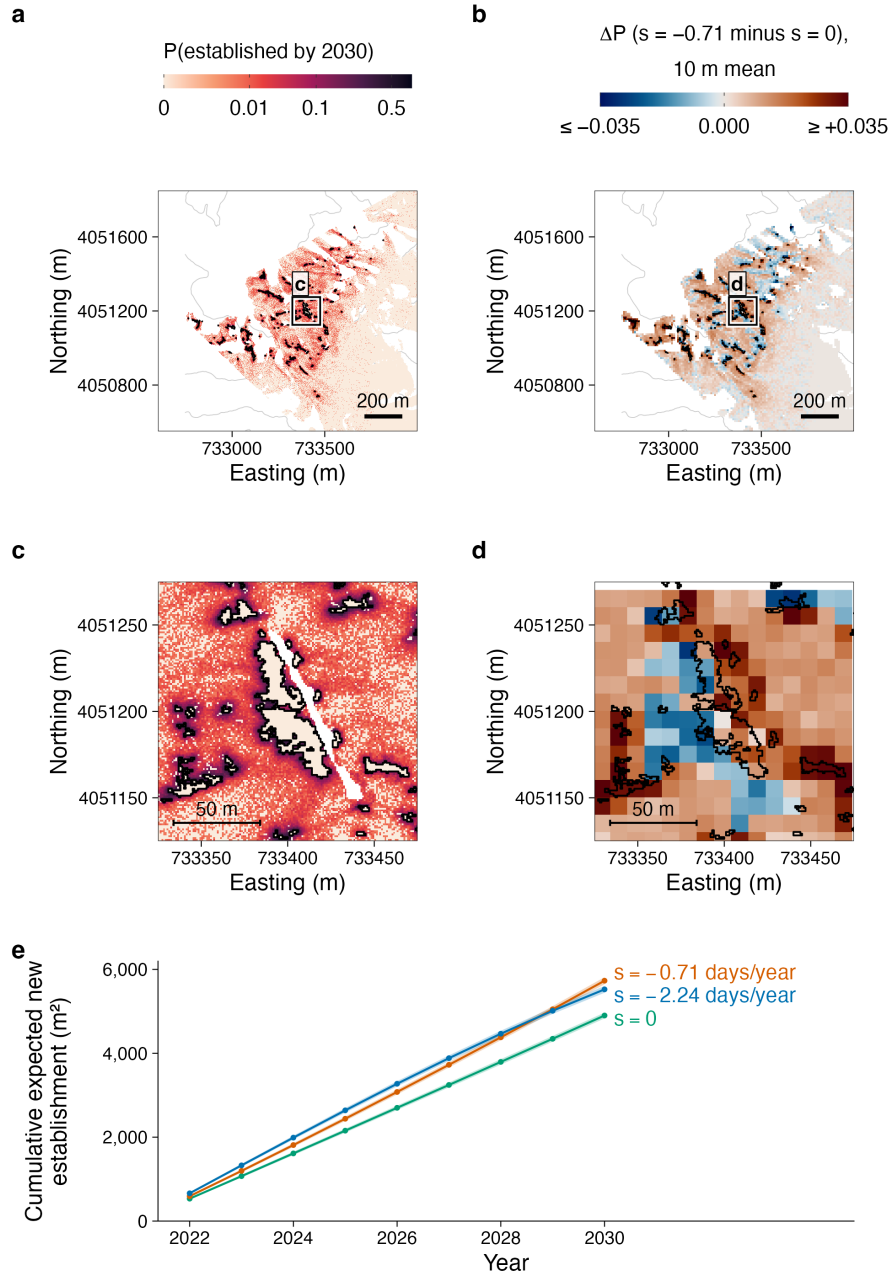


Figure 5: Projected establishment was confined to the vicinity of existing fronts, and the effect of the earlier-snowmelt scenario was small and spatially uneven. Projections to 2030 from the stochastic cellular automaton (200 replicates). (a) Establishment probability by 2030 under the no-change scenario ($s = 0$). (b) Difference between scenarios ($s = -0.71$ days/year minus $s = 0$, averaged over 10 m). Positive values (brown) indicate locations with higher establishment probability under earlier snowmelt; negative values (blue) indicate lower probability. (c, d) Enlargements of the 150 m windows (black boxes) in (a) and (b), respectively; (c) is at 1 m resolution and (d) shows 10 m averages. (e) Annual cumulative expected new establishment area for the 3 scenarios; ribbons show ± 1 SD across replicates. The $s = -2.24$ days/year trajectory remains above the point-estimate scenario through 2028 before crossing it in 2029. Black outlines show the 2021 *Sasa* distribution, restricted to patches exceeding $5 m^2$.

497 pine community (Figure 6 b; Table S12). Observed 2012–2021 establishment
 498 had a similar composition (67%, 11%, and 22%, respectively; Table S12). The
 499 seed-dispersal stratum, Model A’s suitable area within other vegetation in 2021
 500 at the TSS-maximising threshold, was more than an order of magnitude larger
 501 (Figure S7).

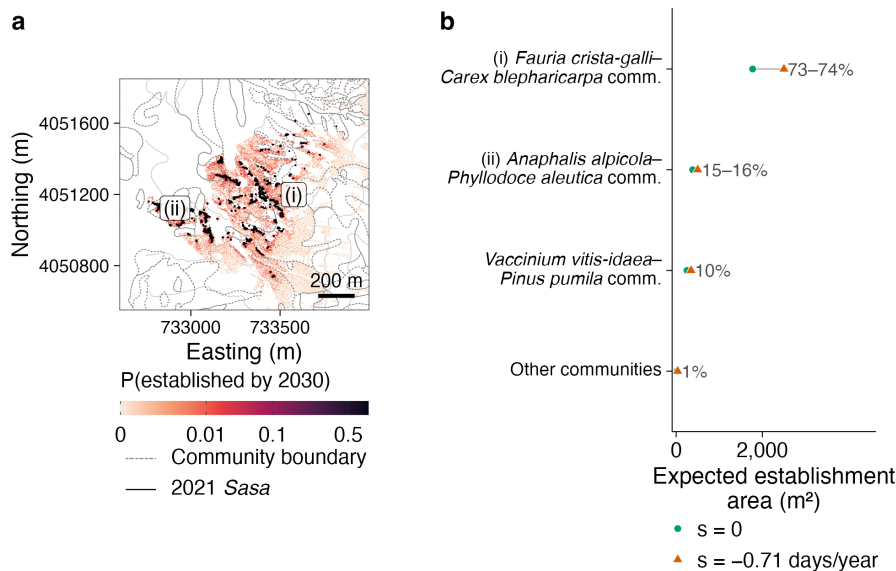


Figure 6: Near-term risk within herbaceous vegetation was concentrated in two snowbed communities adjoining existing patches. (a) Establishment probability by 2030 ($s = 0$) within cells classified as other vegetation in 2021. Dashed lines show community boundaries from the Ministry of the Environment’s 1:25,000 vegetation map; (i) and (ii) locate the main communities shown in (b). (b) Expected establishment area by community (filled circles: $s = 0$; filled triangles: $s = -0.71$ days/year). Percentage labels indicate each community’s share of expected establishment area.

502 4. Discussion

503 Ground-based time-lapse imagery allowed us to map 9-year changes in *Sasa* on
 504 an alpine slope at 1 m resolution and to fit models and project expansion at the
 505 scale at which it occurs. Three findings emerge. First, *Sasa* expanded, but more
 506 modestly than the gross expansion figure alone suggests: net change was +19%
 507 over 9 years. Nearly half of the apparent loss was exchange with dwarf pine,
 508 and the interpretation of this exchange remains unresolved. Second, although
 509 snowmelt regime was among the strongest environmental predictors in both
 510 models, establishment probability was most strongly associated with proximity
 511 to existing patches. Environmentally suitable area far exceeded occupied area,
 512 suggesting that dispersal limitation, rather than a shortage of suitable habitat,
 513 accounts for the gap. Third, process-based projections calibrated to the observed

9-year change indicated approximately 5,000–6,000 m² of spatially restricted establishment by 2030, concentrated in snowbed communities adjoining current patches and only modestly sensitive to earlier snowmelt. We discuss these findings in turn, followed by the role of the method, its limitations, and conservation implications.

4.1. Magnitude and nature of the observed change

The distinction between gross expansion, gross loss, and net change is substantive. Gross expansion of 48% and net change of +19% describe the same 9 years; the difference comprises 2,468 cells classified as *Sasa* in 2012 but not in 2021. Of this loss, 47% was to dwarf pine and 38% to other vegetation; the three deciduous shrub classes (rowans, maple, and montane alder) accounted for only 15%. Transitions to dwarf pine require careful interpretation. Dwarf pine is a prostrate, slow-growing conifer with annual shoot extension of only approximately 4–5 cm (Amagai et al., 2015). Lateral advance over 9 years would amount to at most approximately 0.5 m, less than a single 1 m cell, making extensive concealment of *Sasa* stands by dwarf pine unlikely. Dwarf pine stands on the study slope are themselves expanding (Amagai et al., 2015), however, and their edges interdigitate with *Sasa* at sub-cell scales. Two mechanisms are therefore consistent with the data: lateral growth of dwarf pine branches into boundary cells and shifts in the classification of mixed pixels near boundaries. Indeed, 87.5% of *Sasa*→dwarf pine transition cells directly adjoined dwarf pine present in 2012 (median distance 1.0 m), and isolated transitions at least 5 m from the front accounted for only 1.6% of transition area (19 m²; Table S4, Figure S6). Thus, almost all apparent loss to dwarf pine occurred at dwarf pine boundaries, although the blind interpretation of paired images could not distinguish lateral growth from shifts in classification. Judgement distributions for loss cells were almost identical to those for stable controls (Section 3.1), and the fate of individual 1 m cells could not be resolved at the photographic scale. The boundary interpretation therefore rests on the concentration of adjacent transitions and the constraint imposed by dwarf pine growth rates. Accordingly, we treat loss area as an upper bound on true decline and net change as a conservative estimate of expansion. In contrast, transitions to other vegetation may include genuine local retreat and warrant targeted field verification.

The observed rate, +19% across the slope over 9 years (approximately 2%/year), lies at the lower end of plot-based estimates from Murodo-daira, where *Sasa* patches expanded by 44–260% over 38 years (Yoshida et al., 2016). In the Daisetsuzan Mountains, *Sasa kurilensis* cover in snowbed meadows reportedly increased by up to 47% over 32 years, with fronts advancing at a mean of 39 cm/year and a maximum of 50 cm/year (Kudo et al., 2011); on an annual basis, our observations are of similar magnitude. Continuous mapping across the slope reproduces the direction and order of magnitude reported by plot studies while adding spatial structure that plots cannot provide: where fronts move and where they remain stationary.

557 4.2. Roles of dispersal limitation, environment, and snowmelt

558 Distance from the existing front dominated the establishment model: estab-
559 lishment probability fell by an order of magnitude within the first 10 m of the
560 front (Section 3.4). This distance scale is consistent with the rates of front
561 advance reported for *Sasa* in the Daisetsuzan Mountains (Section 4.1; Kudo
562 et al. (2011)). The strong distance dependence offers a direct explanation for
563 why environmental potential (Model A) exceeded occupied area across a broad
564 range of thresholds, reaching approximately 16 times the occupied area at the
565 TSS-maximising threshold. Taken together, this gap between suitable and occu-
566 pied habitat and the slow advance of fronts are consistent with a non-equilibrium
567 interpretation in which the current *Sasa* distribution has yet to catch up with
568 its environmental potential. If suitable habitat has expanded first, for example
569 in association with earlier snowmelt, and dispersal-limited fronts are still filling
570 that space, a stronger association with proximity than with environment would
571 be expected.

572 Environmental terms describe variation in the rate of expansion from these
573 fronts. In both models, habitat suitability and establishment probability peaked
574 at a snowmelt climatology of approximately DOY 170–175 (Model A peak 172;
575 Model B peak 175) and declined towards both earlier- and later-melting sites.
576 *Sasa* thus has a favourable snowmelt window, and many current fronts adjoin
577 sites on the later-melting side of that window. This response is consistent with
578 the mechanism proposed for Daisetsuzan populations, in which a longer growing
579 season accompanies *Sasa* advance from dwarf pine margins into wetter, later-
580 melting sites (Kudo et al., 2011). It is also consistent with snow-manipulation
581 experiments indicating that snowmelt timing structures tundra and alpine plant
582 communities through growing-season length, soil temperature, and moisture
583 (Wipf and Rixen, 2010; Wahren et al., 2005). Snowmelt DOY is nevertheless
584 a proxy for these covarying conditions and was measured, not manipulated, in
585 this study. Modelled associations are not evidence of causality; separating direct
586 snowmelt effects from those of soils and microclimate requires field measurements.

587 The snowmelt-window interpretation also offers an explanation for the appar-
588 ently unusual behaviour of the projections. Projected establishment was 17%
589 greater under the point-estimate earlier-snowmelt scenario, but slightly lower
590 under the extreme scenario. Sites immediately adjacent to the front, where
591 establishment is concentrated, lie on the late-melting side of the window, so
592 a moderate advance shifts them towards its centre, whereas a larger advance
593 begins to move them beyond it. The response of expansion to snowmelt is
594 therefore non-monotonic, and its sign depends on the position of the front along
595 the snowmelt gradient. This result becomes apparent only when expansion is
596 modelled as a process.

597 4.3. Is *Sasa* expansion a form of shrubification?

598 Woody shrub expansion is among the best-documented vegetation responses to
599 warming in Arctic and alpine tundra (Myers-Smith et al., 2011; Bjorkman et al.,

2018; Carlson et al., 2017). Although *Sasa* is not a woody shrub, it behaves functionally like expanding tundra shrubs: it forms dense, tall, evergreen stands that exclude subordinate species (Kudo et al., 2011), and snowbed vegetation recovers after *Sasa* removal (Kudo et al., 2017). It differs from typical shrubs in two respects, however. First, rhizome expansion proceeds from existing fronts with a metre-scale dispersal kernel, making it more spatially predictable than the spread of shrubs that establish new nuclei through seed dispersal and, in principle, amenable to targeted removal at the front. Second, *Sasa* competes with dwarf pine, which is also expanding under warming (Amagai et al., 2015). Because most of the bidirectional *Sasa*–dwarf pine exchanges in the transition matrix occurred at boundary cells whose nature we could not resolve, whether the two expanding taxa also replace each other remains an open question that merits study in its own right.

4.4. Ground-based cameras among vegetation monitoring approaches

The role of ground-based cameras in this framework is complementary to that of satellites. Satellite time series offer continuity over decades and comparability among regions, making them well suited to analyses of landscape-scale greening and range shifts. Ground-based cameras provide sub-metre resolution and daily revisits within a fixed field of view, matching the scale of processes underlying the changes observed by satellites: patch-front advance, the sequence of snowmelt within snowbeds, and shifts in community boundaries. Our study illustrates what becomes possible in this gap: an establishment model fitted at the resolution of the process. The limitations are also specific: a fixed oblique viewpoint, coverage of at most a few km², dependence on continuous imagery throughout the period of interest, and restriction to taxa distinguishable in photographs, such as large or phenologically distinctive plants, including *Sasa* and dwarf pine. The last limitation could be partly relaxed through field collection of training data.

4.5. Limitations

(1) *Two time points*. The establishment model was fitted to a single 9-year interval, and projections assume stationary annual establishment rates conditional on the covariates. Independent validation was limited to spatial block exclusion, which indicated that *where* establishment occurs can be predicted reasonably well in unseen areas (AUC 0.79–0.86), whereas errors in *how much* occurs are substantial (block-level ratios 0.7–2.0). (2) *Snowmelt trends*. A 10-year record cannot detect trends of plausible magnitude. The scenarios evaluate no change, the point estimate of the observed slope, and its lower confidence limit; they are not predictions of snowmelt itself. (3) *Patch rule*. Projections depend strongly on the assumption that new colonies contribute to expansion only after forming an established patch (>5 m²); removing this rule triples projected area. The biological rationale is given in Section 2.6, but the threshold is not a measured parameter. (4) *Classification*. Map accuracy estimates are upper bounds (see Section 2.3), and the *Sasa*–dwarf pine exchanges show that boundary pixels are the most uncertain parts of the maps. These

are precisely the pixels that define the front. (5) *Environmental coverage*. Soil properties, soil temperature, moisture, and freeze–thaw exposure were not measured. The strong distance term may partly absorb the effects of unmeasured, spatially structured variables. (6) *Seed dispersal*. The establishment model captures only rhizome expansion. Establishment from seed following flowering events (Miyazaki et al., 2009; Mizuki et al., 2014) bypasses the distance constraint, which is why environmental potential is presented as a separate risk stratum. Even when seeds arrive, however, germination and seedling establishment may impose constraints independent of dispersal.

4.6. Conservation implications

Two practical implications follow. First, near-term risk is spatially concentrated and can be assigned to specific locations. Approximately nine tenths of expected establishment within herbaceous vegetation by 2030 is projected to fall in two snowbed communities on the Ministry of the Environment’s vegetation map, the *Fauria crista-galli*–*Carex blepharicarpa* and *Anaphalis alpicola*–*Phyllodoce aleutica* communities, and to lie within a few metres of existing patches. The remaining tenth, allocated to the dwarf pine community, reflects herbaceous cells within coarse 1:25,000 polygons rather than establishment beneath dwarf pine canopies. Removal or containment at patch fronts bordering snowbeds is therefore a high-priority candidate intervention; intervention costs and regrowth following removal were not evaluated here. Second, the much larger environmentally suitable area, most of which is unreachable by rhizomes within the projection horizon, is where establishment from seed would matter. Targeted surveillance for new isolated patches after flowering events, rather than continuous monitoring of the entire slope, would be a proportionate response. The presence or absence of rare species within risk areas cannot be determined at the resolution of the Ministry’s 1:25,000 vegetation map; field surveys are the natural next step.

More generally, this framework separates two questions that a single suitability map can conflate: where environmental conditions permit a species, and how far it can actually reach. It answers the latter with a process model calibrated to observed change. For species such as *Sasa* that expand at metre scales, fixed cameras make this calibration possible at the scale of the process itself. The study slope is a maritime, monsoon-influenced alpine environment with exceptionally deep snow; in continental settings with shallower snowpack and greater freeze–thaw exposure, the balance between snowmelt and other constraints may differ. The same logic could nevertheless apply to other expanding species in snowy environments where comparable image records are available.

5. Conclusion

Over 9 years, *Sasa* expanded on the study slope with a net change of +19% (gross expansion 48%, gross loss 29%). Establishment probability was most strongly associated with proximity to existing patches, with further variation

686 associated with snowmelt regime and topography. Environmentally suitable area
 687 greatly exceeded occupied area, suggesting that dispersal limitation accounts for
 688 the gap. A process model calibrated to observed change projected approximately
 689 4,900–5,700 m² of further establishment by 2030 under scenarios conditioned on
 690 the observed decade rather than forecasts of snowmelt, concentrated in snowbed
 691 communities adjoining current patches and only modestly sensitive to earlier
 692 snowmelt. Using *Sasa* as an example, this study shows that ground-based
 693 time-lapse imagery fills the gap between plot surveys and satellite observations,
 694 allowing metre-scale expansion to be observed and projected at the resolution of
 695 the process itself.

696 Acknowledgements

697 This research was supported by JSPS KAKENHI Grant Number JP23H00729.

698 Conflict of Interest Statement

699 The authors declare no conflicts of interest.

700 Author Contributions

701 **Ryotaro Okamoto:** Conceptualization (equal); Data curation (lead); Method-
 702 ology (lead); Software (lead); Writing – original draft (lead); Writing – review &
 703 editing (equal). **Hiroyuki Oguma:** Conceptualization (equal); Investigation
 704 (equal); Project administration (lead); Supervision (lead); Writing – review &
 705 editing (equal). **Reiko Ide:** Conceptualization (equal); Data curation (equal);
 706 Writing – review & editing (equal).

707 Data Availability Statement

708 The imagery-derived vegetation and snowmelt rasters, terrain predictors, all
 709 fitted model objects, projection outputs, and scripted analysis pipeline with
 710 its acceptance tests are permanently archived at Zenodo (<https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.22745234>). A development mirror is maintained at <https://github.com/Okam/SasaSDMPaper>.
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